

Get Noticed, Get Clicked

There are no shortcuts to currying favour with search engines, it seems

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With more than 135 million Web sites out there, you've got your job cut out to get your Web site in front of surfers. Search engines have long been recognised as a good source of visitor traffic, and over the years, Search Engine Optimisation (or SEO as its popularly called) has developed into an active, dynamic industry in its own right.

A Little History

If you still think stuffing keywords into the meta tags of your Web pages are what will push you up the rankings in the SERPs (Search Engine Results Pages), this is a wake-up call. You've been sleeping and "keyword stuffing" is about as dead as it can get. The Net has moved on, and how! The practice of keyword stuffing originated in the '90s when Webmasters found that search engines gave special weightage to the META tag of HTML pages (right-click on a Web page and view its source, and inspect the <meta> HTML tag near the top). This was in the days when bandwidth and hardware were still at a premium. Canny Webmasters began stuffing keywords into their meta tags, which pushed them up in the SERP rankings. Search engines quickly caught on, compensating for the skew in the results, and ever since it has been a game of tag between the search engines and the SEO industry. SEO consultants discover a way to gain an edge in the rankings; the search engines move in and plug the hole.

What Search Engines Do

These days, most search engines look at multiple factors in determining a Web site's ranking in the search results. Some are known, most are

unknown. The search algorithm is the secret sauce that drives the accuracy of the search results, and is therefore one of the most closely-guarded secrets. Each search engine has a different set of factors to determine rankings. Google, it is rumoured, uses more than 200 data points! The others (Yahoo! and Windows Live are the main ones which matter these days) are not far behind.

One of the known factors that play a role in determining the rankings in Google is PageRank. This is a score that Google assigns to a Web site on a scale of 1 to 10. A higher PageRank gives you higher weightage. PageRank itself is determined using "...more than 500 million variables and 2 billion terms." (<http://www.google.com/corporate/tech.html>). And like PageRank, there are other hundreds of other factors that go into determining the ranking in the SERP.

Black Hat Vs. White Hat

Even with these many factors to juggle around with, some Webmasters resort to using deceptive practices in an attempt to fool the search engines and push up their ranking. This using of deception—and techniques that attempt to fool the search algorithm—is known as Black Hat SEO, and search engines have special filters that monitor for known Black Hat techniques. If you are looking for long-term recognition and are building a quality Web site, Black Hat SEO is just not the way to go! Search engines penalise sites that knowingly or unknowingly use Black Hat techniques, and this can include suspension or even complete removal from the search engine's listings.

Case in point: the German Web sites of BMW and RICOH were removed temporarily from the search listings for using deceptive techniques. They were only restored after they addressed the issue.

